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Acme Ledger Approvals Review

Where the approval queue loses time, and what to change first

PREPARED FOR	Acme Ledger (fictional)
DATE	2026-10-17
VERSION	0.1
STATUS	Sample

01 — EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The approval queue loses most of its time before a human ever sees an item

GOVERNING THOUGHT

Routing rules, not reviewer capacity, set the pace of approvals. Fixing three rules recovers more time than adding reviewers. INFERENCE

128
open approvals

4.2 days
median wait

61%
held before first review

Routing dominates. Items wait in a holding state while rules decide who owns them. OBSERVED

Capacity is secondary. Reviewers clear items within a day once they receive them. OBSERVED

Median wait is measured from submission to first reviewer action.

02 — DIAGNOSIS

Three rules account for nearly all holding time, and each can be changed without new tooling

The cut is by cause of delay: ownership, thresholds, and notifications.

Ownership

Unowned items stall. Items from new cost centers match no routing rule and sit until someone triages them by hand.[1] OBSERVED

INSIGHT

Every day an item sits unowned adds a median 0.9 days to total wait. Ownership is the first lever.

EXHIBIT 1

Median wait by cause of delay, days

Cause	Items	Median wait (days)	Share of delay
Unowned	412	3.8	52%
Over threshold	190	2.1	21%
Missing notice	133	1.4	14%
Other	80	0.9	13%

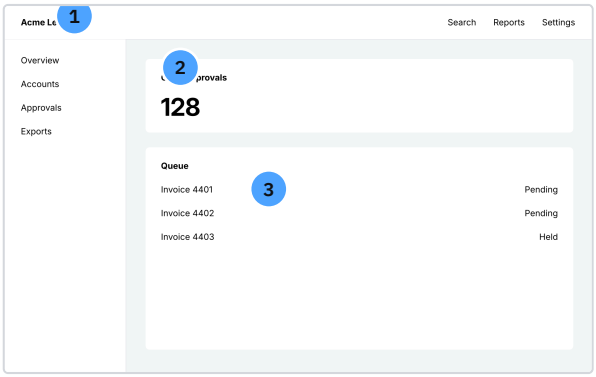
Source: Illustrative data, fictional sample.

Thresholds

Limits trigger double review. Items above the threshold need a second approver even when the first is the budget owner. INFERENCE

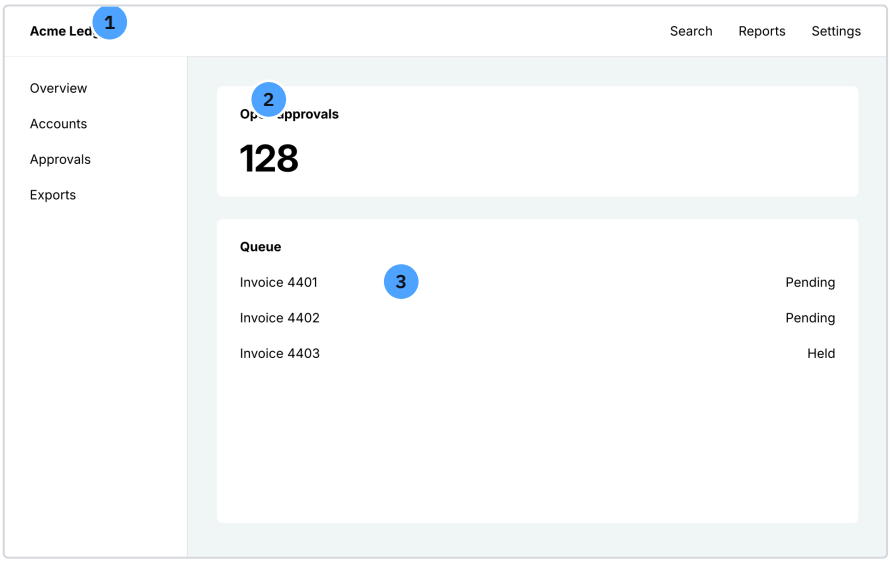
> Nobody told me the item was waiting on me. — Interview 7, fictional

[1] Illustrative source, accessed 2026-10-17, published 2026-01-05.



1 Open approvals count hides held items.
2 Queue rows show status without owner.
3 No filter exists for held items.

Figure 1. The approvals dashboard shows the count but not the cause of each hold.



1 Count tile.
2 Row status.
3 Missing filter.

Figure 2. Full-measure version of the same screen.